

The Apocryphon of John

Codex Reference: II,1; III,1; IV,1; BG 8502,2

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Editor's Introduction

(II,1, III,1, IV,1, AND BG 8502,2)

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The Apocryphon of John is an important work of mythological Gnosticism. Using the framework of a revelation delivered by the resurrected Christ to John the son of Zebedee, this tractate offers a remarkably clear description of the creation, fall, and salvation of humanity; the mythological description is developed largely in terms of the early chapters of Genesis. Reports of the church fathers indicate that some of them were familiar with the contents of *The Apocryphon of John*: the teachings of certain Gnostics described by Irenaeus are very similar to the cosmological teachings of the present tractate. Though Irenaeus apparently did not know *The Apocryphon of John* in its present form, it is certain that the main teachings of the tractate existed before 185 C.E., the date of Irenaeus' work *Against Heresies*. The Apocryphon of John was still used in the eighth century by the Audians of Mesopotamia.

The Apocryphon of John supplies answers to two basic questions: What is the origin of evil? How can we escape from this evil world to our heavenly home? The cosmogeny, in spite of its exotic details, also seeks to answer these questions. The highest deity is defined in terms of an abstract Greek concept of perfection, a perfection which excludes all anthropomorphism and all involvement in the world. From this supreme deity emanates a series of light-beings, including Christ and Sophia.

According to *The Apocryphon of John*, the fall occurs when Sophia desires to bring forth a being without the approval of the great Spirit or her consort. Consequently, she produces the monstrous creator-god Yaldabaoth, who still possesses some of the light-power of his mother. Yaldabaoth creates angels to rule over the world and aid in the creation of man; man himself is fashioned after the perfect Father's image, which was mirrored on the water. Man comes to life when Yaldabaoth is tricked into breathing light-power into him. Thus begins a continuous struggle between the powers of light and the powers of darkness for the possession of the divine particles in man. The evil powers put man in a material body to keep him imprisoned, and also create woman and sexual desire to spread the particles of light and make escape more difficult. Finally Christ is sent down to save humanity by reminding people of their heavenly origin. Only those who possess this knowledge and have lived ascetic lives can return to the realm of light; the others are reincarnated until they also come to saving knowledge.

Three versions of *The Apocryphon of John* are known. III,1 and BG 8502,2 represent independent translations into Coptic of a short Greek recension of the work. II,1 and IV,1 are copies of the same Coptic translation of a long Greek recension. The English translation presented here is

of the long recension. Page and line numbers are given for II,1, except where IV,1 preserved text which was omitted in II,1 through scribal error.

II 1, 1–32, 9 = IV 1, 1–49, 28